

SEATED IN A HOTEL ROOM IN Jhansi, actor Mona Singh's beaming face shows no signs of the weariness of shooting relentlessly. By her own account, she has shot four web series in 2023, which, going by the long-format duration, is as good as doing eight films. Best known for essaying Jassi in the popular TV show *Jassi Jaisi Koi Nahin*, a remake of the American sitcom *Ugly Betty*, Singh is currently basking in the release of three web series this year—*Kafas* (SonyLIV), *Made in Heaven* season two (Amazon Prime) and the latest, *Kaala Paani* (Netflix). So omnipresent is the actor that Singh's social media following has blown up, with fans hailing her as the "Pankaj Tripathi of web series". "I can just feel the change," she says. "I'm grateful for witnessing these beautiful times that have come after a long gap."

This may be the most prolific year for Singh, but she was, in fact, one of the first to foresee the potential of streaming back in 2018, when she appeared in The Viral Fever's *Yeh Meri Family*, a family show about growing up in the 1990s, told and seen through the eyes of a child. The show initially went under the radar, but picked up through word-of-mouth publicity, with Singh earning praise for playing a doting mother of three. "I saw people were starting to explore shorter forms and watching content on their phones. People were not going to be time-bound anymore [like with television]," she says.

Kaala Paani sees Singh team up once again with Sameer Saxena, the creator and director of *Yeh Meri Family*. The survival drama is one of the first to be shot extensively in the Andamans and features Singh as a doctor and researcher. "She doesn't like mediocrity, doesn't get along with people and she's the boss whom

CINEMA

HOW THE WES WAS WON

Key grip Sanjay Sami discusses his work on some of the world's most famous films and his latest collaboration with Wes Anderson



His IMDB listing is like every film we've ever liked. From cult Bollywood ones like *Dil Chahta Hai* and *Don* to multiplex gems like *Being Cyrus*, *Delhi Belly* and *Manto* and mega spinners like *Brahmastra*. His international creds are like, well, something out of the movies. Think *The Bourne Supremacy*, *The Curious Case of Benjamin Button*, *Eat, Pray, Love*, *Mission Impossible: Ghost Protocol*, *The Hundred-Foot Journey*, *Doctor Strange*, *Tenet*, and OTT series like *Sense8* and *Shantaram*, Sami has worked with the best in the biz. Quite the achievement for someone who started adult life as a commercial diver and wasn't remotely interested in cinema!

From Martin Scorsese to Christopher Nolan, Mira Nair to Gurinder Chadha, they have all had Sami on set, in charge of all camera movement and 'shaping the light'. What makes Sami such a valuable part of these top-notch teams? "To be a good grip, your primary job is as a problem-solver. Almost all the time, things won't go exactly according to plan. What sets you apart is how quickly you can find another solution," he says.

And that's perhaps why filmmaker Wes Anderson, known for his visually stunning films, relies on Sami the way he does. Right from *The Darjeeling Limited* (2007), when the team reached out to Sami to come onboard as Key Grip and petitioned for his visa, it's been an exciting journey. After many projects such as *The Grand Budapest Hotel* and *The French Dispatch*, their most recent collaborations are *Asteroid City* and the four Netflix shorts based on



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